NO MORE A PIPE DREAM

Millions of Indian women no longer have to trudge miles to fetch water, as now they can get water through taps in their own homes

By AMARNATH K. MENON



ON TAP
Women fill water from a tap installed at their home in Sindrath village in Sirohi district, Rajasthan

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

THE DRUDGERY

Getting up at the crack of dawn. Collecting all the pots in the house and making your way to the nearest well or hand pump, joining an endless queue. An interminable wait for the trickle to fill your vessels. And the long march back home, a tower of pots perched precariously on your head. That was long the fate of women in India, losing 150 million work days every year collecting water, according to the NGO International Development Organisation. Summer brought with it dread, and the prospect of no water. Many bored deep into the ground to strike the elixir of life, but the surfeit of borewells sucked the ground dry. Tap connection was a luxury 82 per cent of India's rural households had never encountered till six years back.

THE EASE OF LIVING

That reality stands reversed today, with nearly 80 per cent, or more than 154 million, out of over 190 million rural households in India boasting a tap connection. Helping bring about that change is the Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM), launched in 2019. Armed with an outlay of Rs 3.6 lakh crore, and leveraging technology for transparency and real-time monitoring, JJM has been working to provide tap connections in every village house. How? By building infrastructure for water supply and sustaining water resources to ensure water flow.

Sundry challenges may have thwarted JJM's ambition for full coverage in five years, but 11 states and Union territories have achieved the seemingly impossible. Compared to just one in six households having a tap water connection, three in four rural households now have one. Lack of access to tap water at home, JJM data reveals, is a concern only in four states. West Bengal has the lowest coverage at 53.9 per cent, followed by Kerala at 54.13 per cent, Jharkhand at 54.62 per cent and Rajasthan at 54.95 per cent.

WHO estimates total tap coverage can help save 55 million hours daily, otherwise spent collecting water

The transformative effects of such a mission are hardly in doubt. The World Health Organization estimates that full coverage could help save 55 million hours daily, safe drinking water could prevent nearly 400,000 deaths from diarrhoeal diseases. Access to clean drinking water is a human right, something the United Nations General Assembly recognised in 2010. ■